



IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Independent drama

DIRECTOR

Steven Soderbergh

WRITER

Steven Soderbergh

STARS

James Spader, Andie MacDowell, Peter Gallagher, Laura San Giacomo

BEFORE

1974 John Cassavetes' *A Woman Under the Influence* is financed by the director mortgaging his house; it wins him an Oscar nomination.

AFTER

1991 Richard Linklater's *Slacker* is a freewheeling amble through Austin, Texas, that receives acclaim amid renewed interest in new young American filmmakers.

1998 Soderbergh has a mainstream hit with *Out of Sight*, starring George Clooney.

BEING HAPPY ISN'T ALL THAT GREAT

SEX, LIES, AND VIDEOTAPE / 1989

Graham (James Spader), the protagonist of *Sex, Lies, and Videotape*, is young, handsome, intelligent—and impotent. He achieves sexual satisfaction only when watching videos he has made of female acquaintances talking about their sexual fantasies. Ann (Andie

MacDowell) is married to Graham's old friend John (Peter Gallagher), who is cheating on her with her sister. Ann and John no longer make love, and Ann thinks sex is overrated. At first horrified by Graham's unusual predilections, about which he is disarmingly open, Ann soon opens herself up on camera—and in the process discovers that she is not quite who she thought she was.

The movie launched the career of director Steven Soderbergh, who would go on to become one of the most unpredictable talents in American movies. Just as significantly, it was vital in kindling a new wave of US independent cinema. After his movie won the Palme d'Or, Soderbergh's success helped lay the ground for creators like Spike Lee, Richard Linklater, and Quentin Tarantino, who work outside the studio system. ■

Written in a week and made on a small budget, *Sex, Lies, and Videotape* nonetheless managed to achieve box-office success.



What else to watch: *Do the Right Thing* (1989, p.264) ■ *Slacker* (1991) ■ *Reservoir Dogs* (1992, p.340) ■ *Safe* (1995) ■ *In the Company of Men* (1997)